

Lecture 14: Culture is Ordinary

Made in Britain: working class culture, race and 'Cultural Studies'



British Cultural Studies: Origins



E.P. Thompson:
The Making of
the English
Working Class
(1963)
'Culture from
below'



The Making of the English Working Class

Thompson



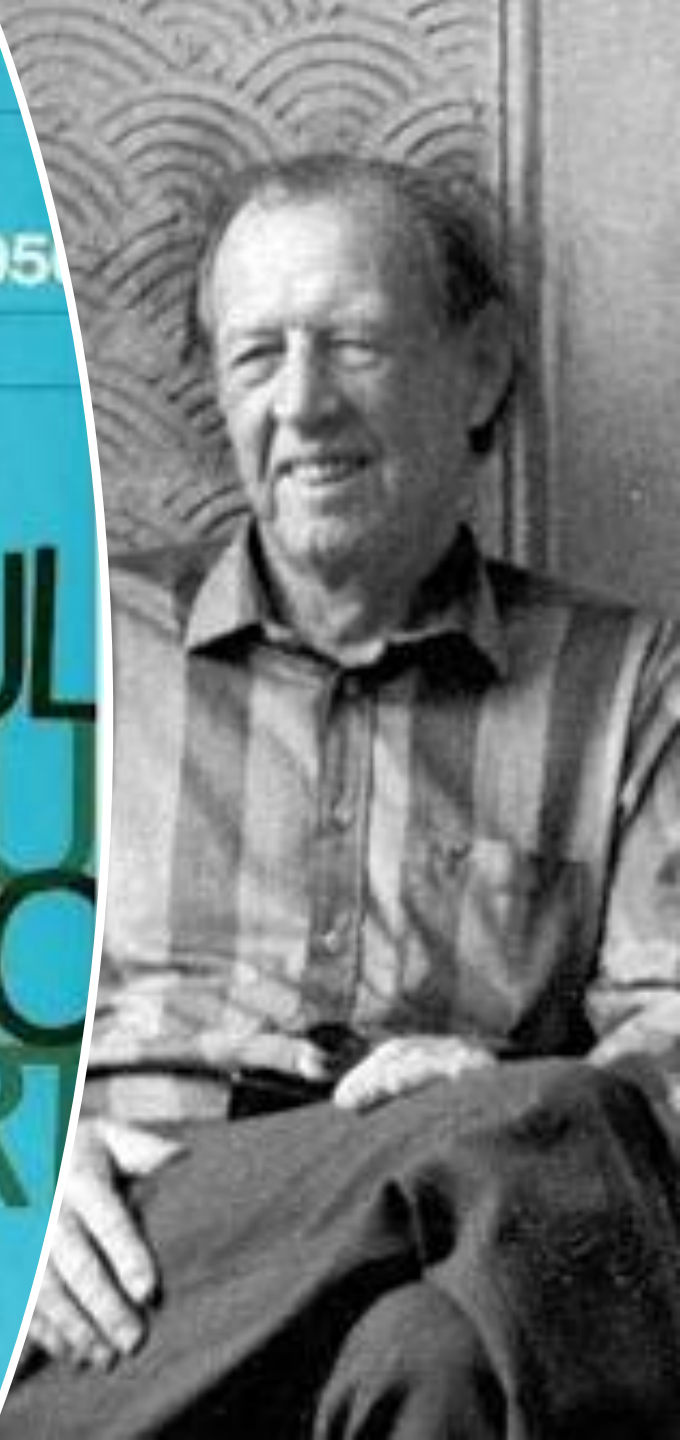
Raymond
Williams:
Culture and
Society
(1958)

a Pelican Book

Culture and
Society 1780-1950

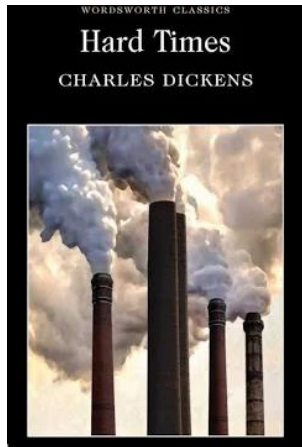
Raymond Williams

ASSCUL
REINDU
RYDEVIC
RACYART

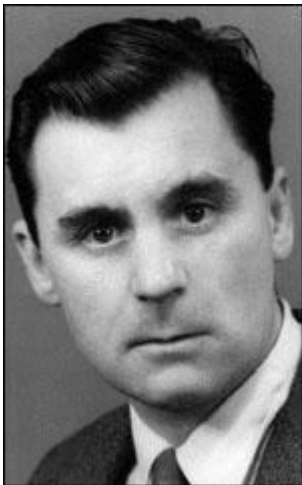


Structure of feeling

Pre-emergent cultural experiences of a **class** not yet articulated in **formal ideology**

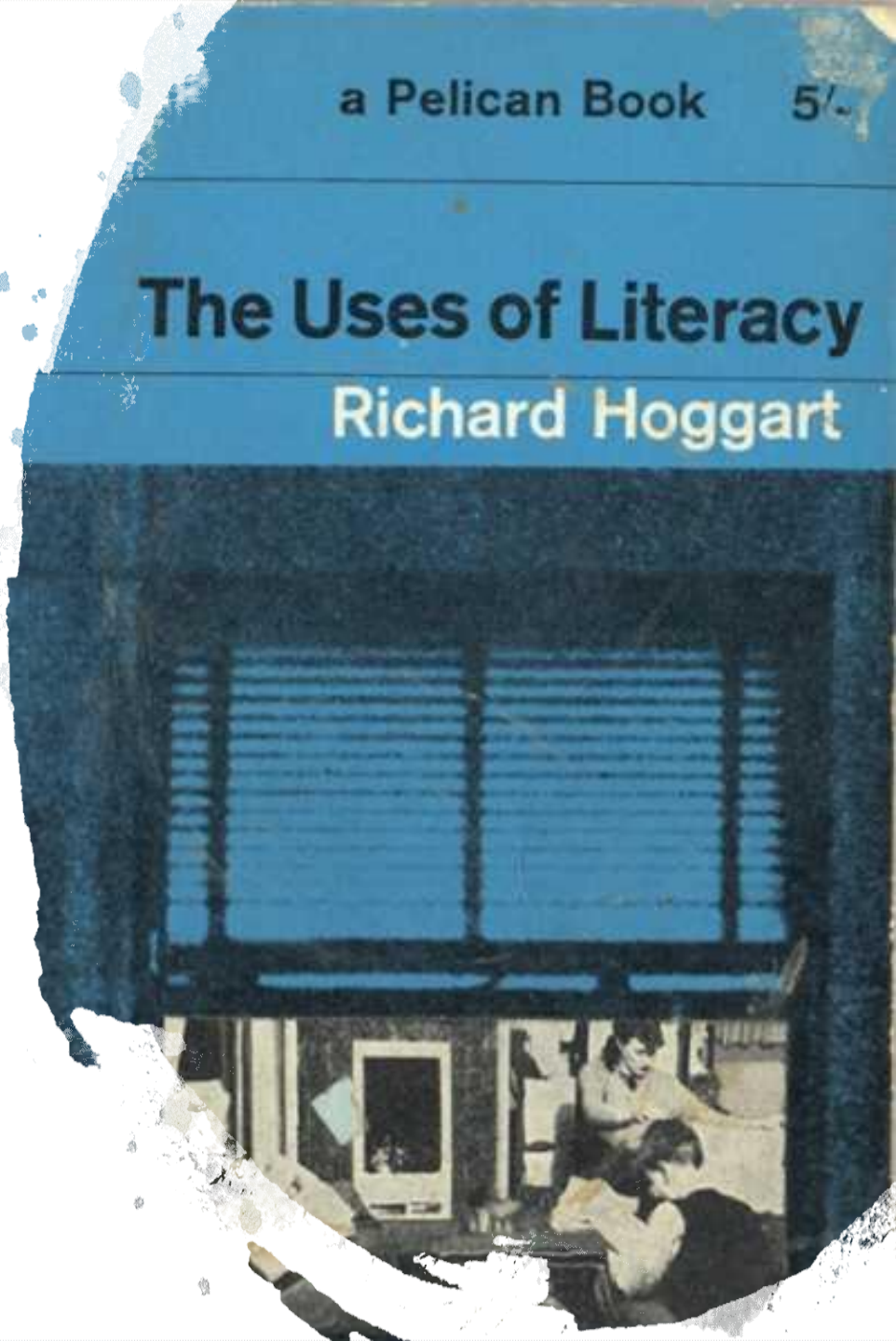


British Cultural Studies: The Centre for Contemporary Cultural Studies (est. 1964)



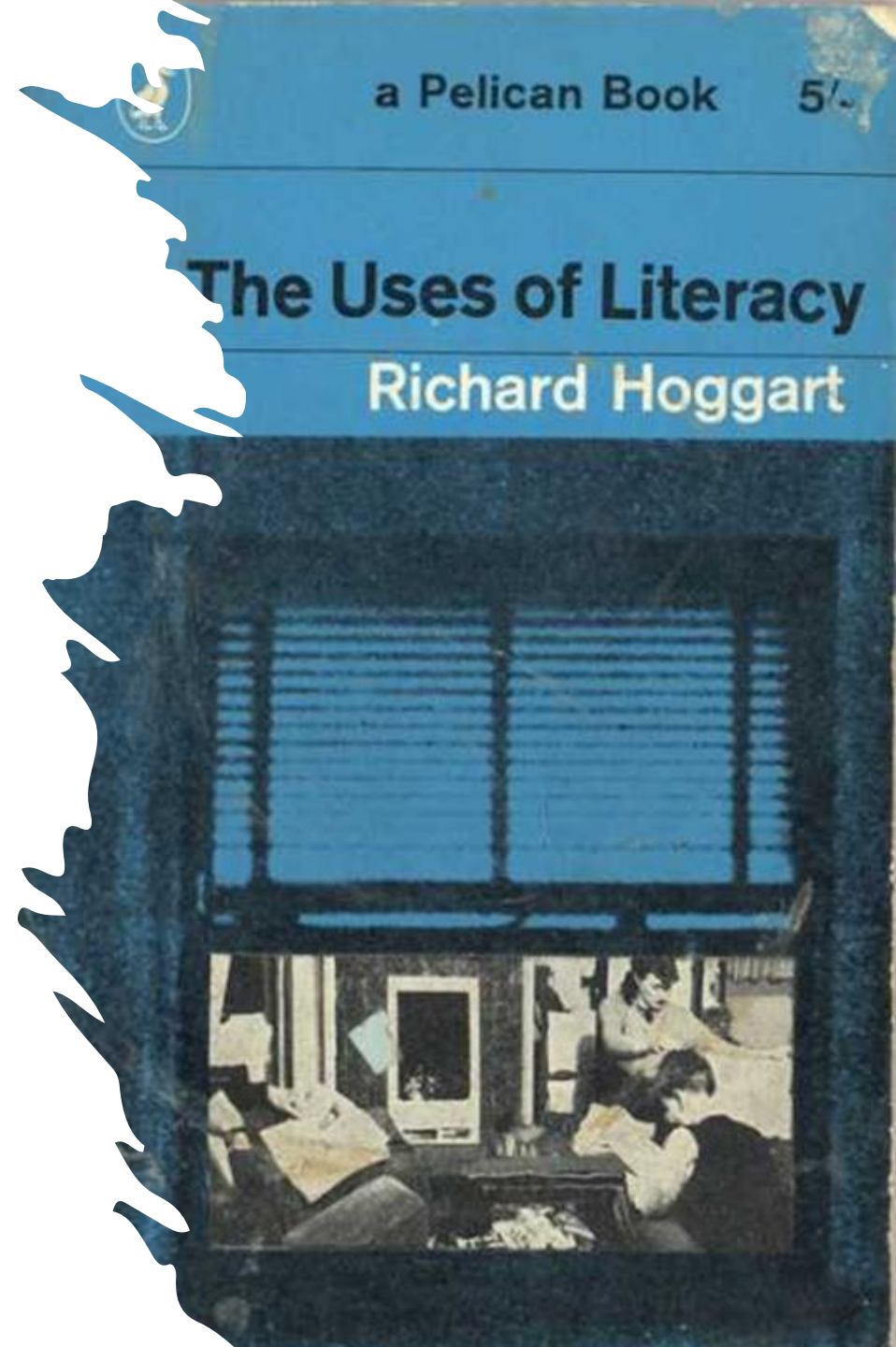
Richard Hoggart (1918-)

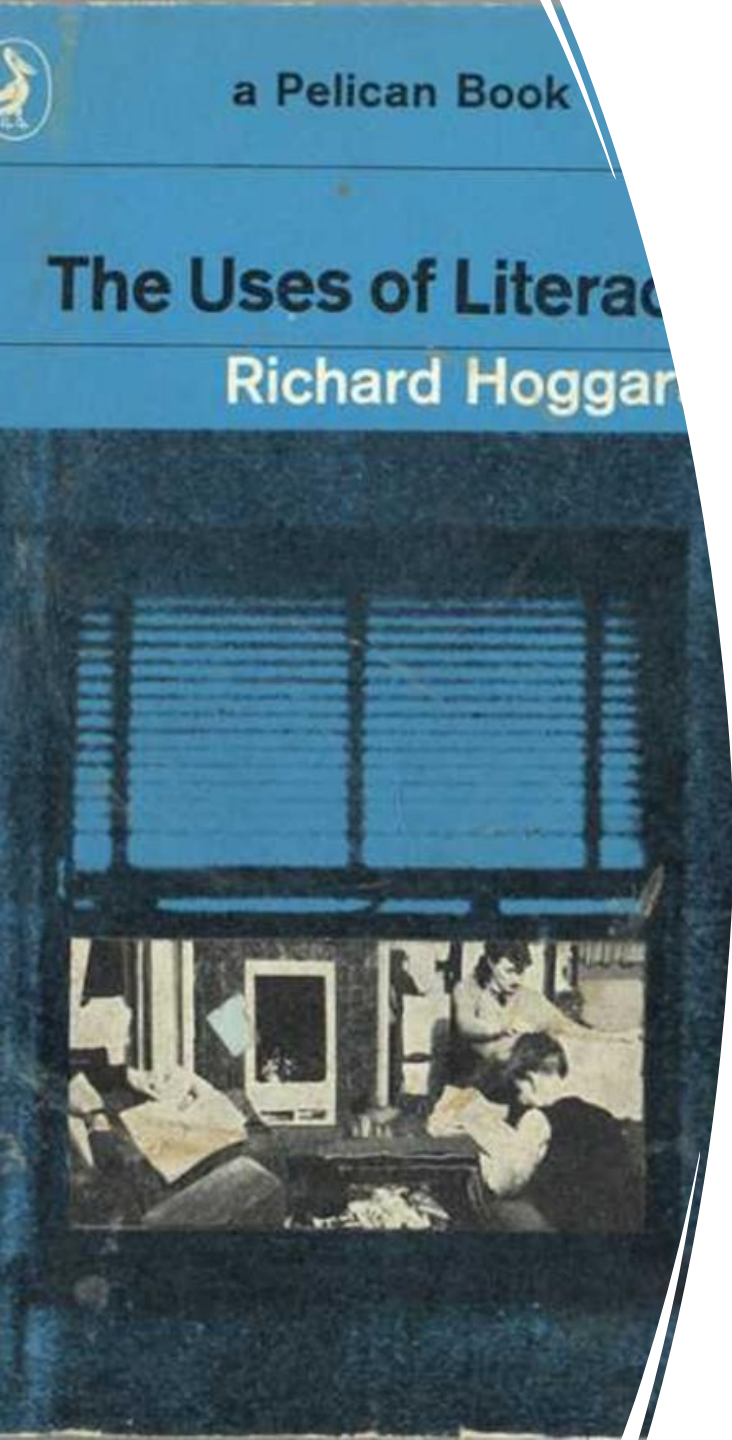
- ❖ *Uses of Literacy* (1957) = a book of two halves: the first half describes the working-class culture of Hoggart's own youth during the 1930s; the second half describes this culture under threat from the new forms of mass entertainment of the 1950s.
- ❖ 1930s reflects a so-called 'lived', 'self-made' culture whereas the 1950s culture is marked by the demands of commercialisation and mass production: 'a world where things are done for the people'.
- ❖ 'We are moving towards the creation of a mass culture; that the remnants of what was at least in parts an urban culture 'of the people' are being destroyed; and that the new mass culture is in some important ways less healthy than the crude culture it is replacing'.



Unbent Springs: the Anxious and Uprooted

'Almost every working-class boy [sic] who goes through the process of further education by scholarships finds himself chafing against his environment during adolescence. He is at the friction-point of two cultures ... As childhood gives way to adolescence and that to manhood this kind of boy tends to be progressively cut off from the ordinary life of his group ... He has left his class, at least in spirit, by being in certain ways unusual; and he is still unusual in another class, too tense and over-wound ... He is sad and also solitary; he finds it difficult to establish contact even with others in his condition.'





Invitation to a Candy Floss World

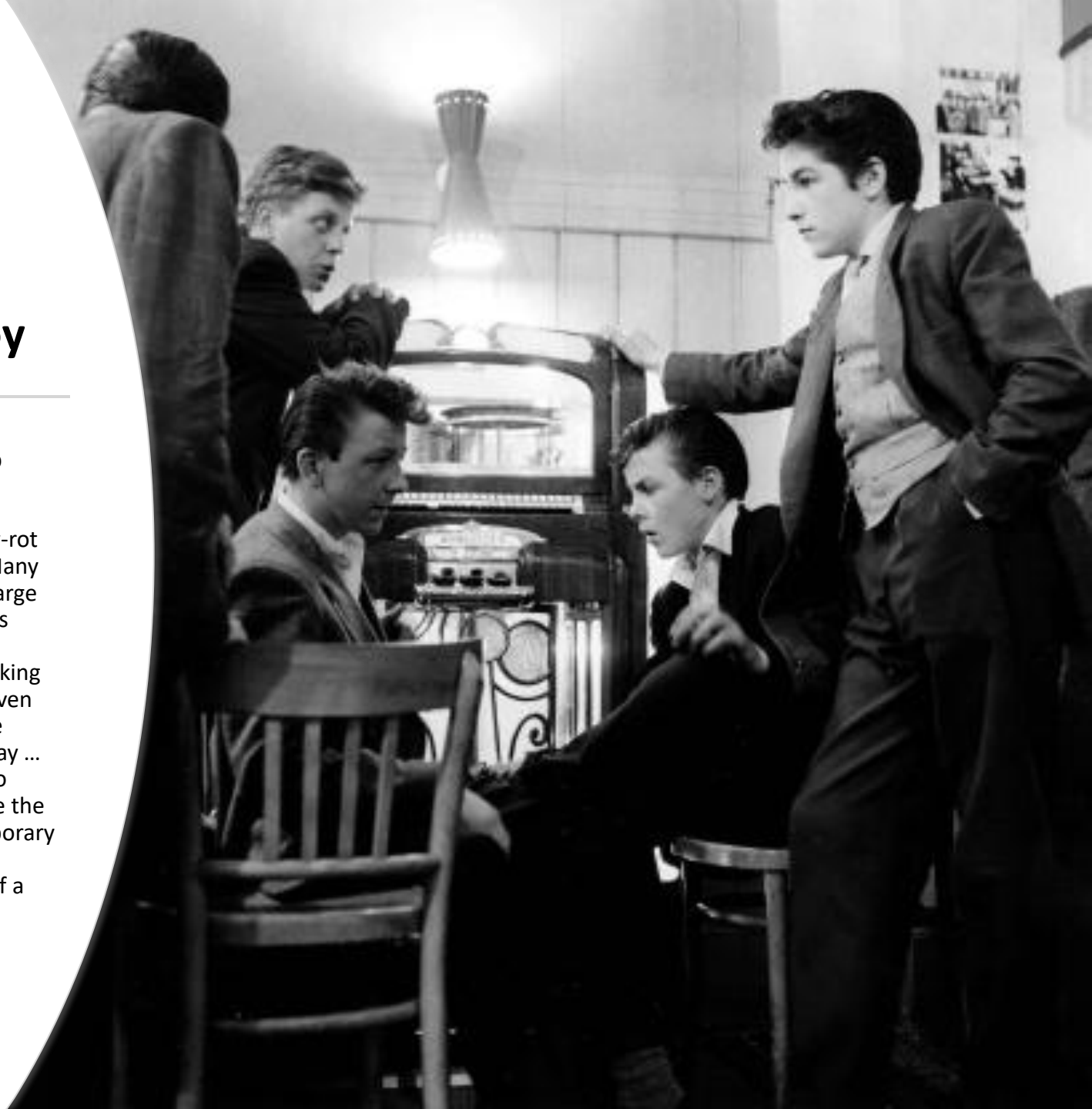
- ❖ Not so much a moral decline in the working class as it is a decline in the moral seriousness of the culture provided for the working class:
- ❖ 'Most mass entertainments are in the end what D.H. Lawrence described as 'anti-life'. They are full of a corrupt brightness, of improper appeals and moral evasions ... they offer nothing which can really grip the brain or heart'



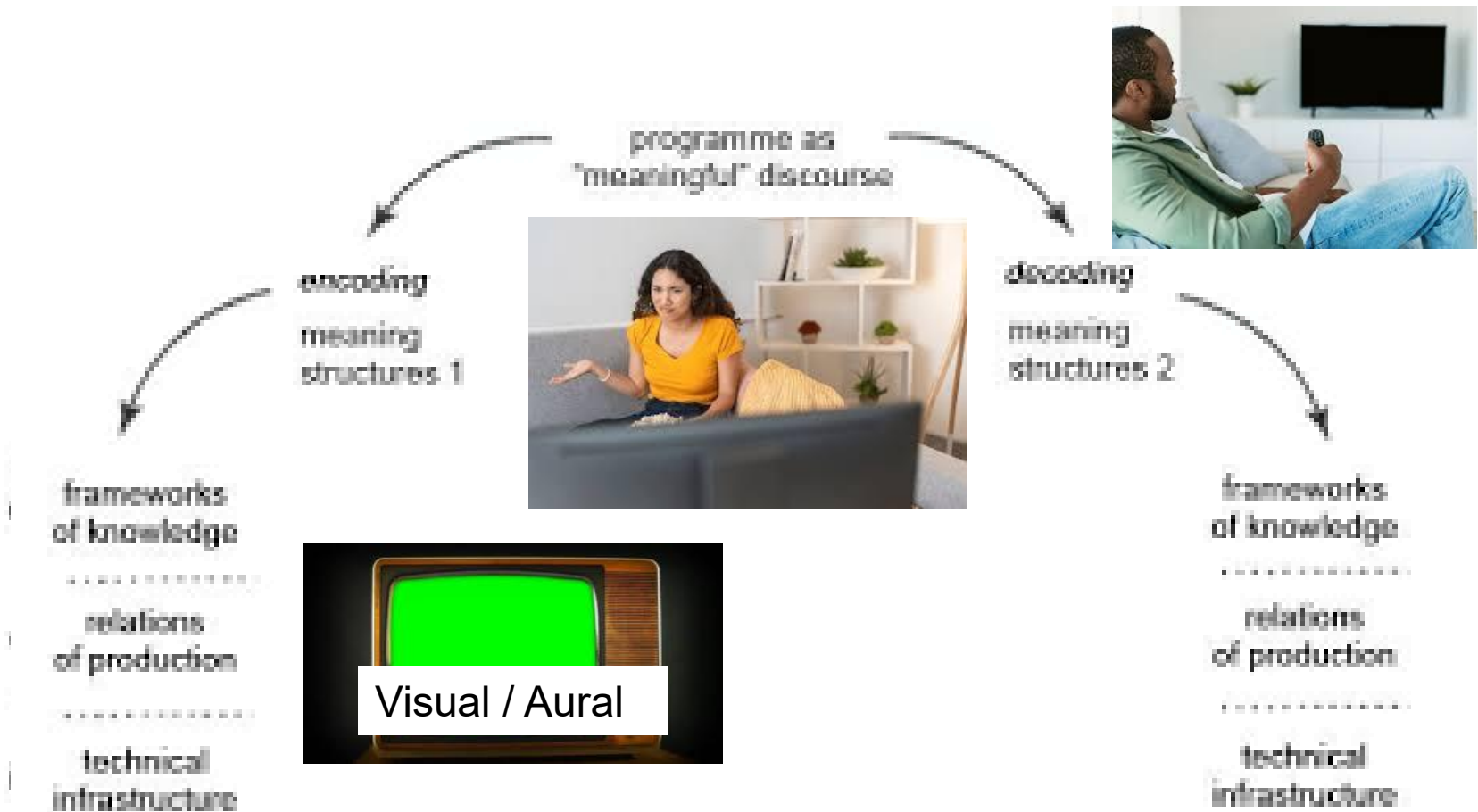
Café Culture?

The Juke Box Boy

- Compared even with the pub around the corner, this is all a peculiarly thin and pallid form of dissipation, a sort of spiritual dry-rot amid the odour of boiled milk. Many of the customers are living to a large extent in a myth world ... perhaps most of them are rather less intelligent than the average [working class youth], and are therefore even more exposed than others to the debilitating mass trends of the day ... they have no responsibilities ... to themselves or others ... these are the figures some important contemporary forces are tending to create , the directionless and tamed helots of a machine-minding class ...



Hall 'Encoding and Decoding in the Television Discourse' (1973)



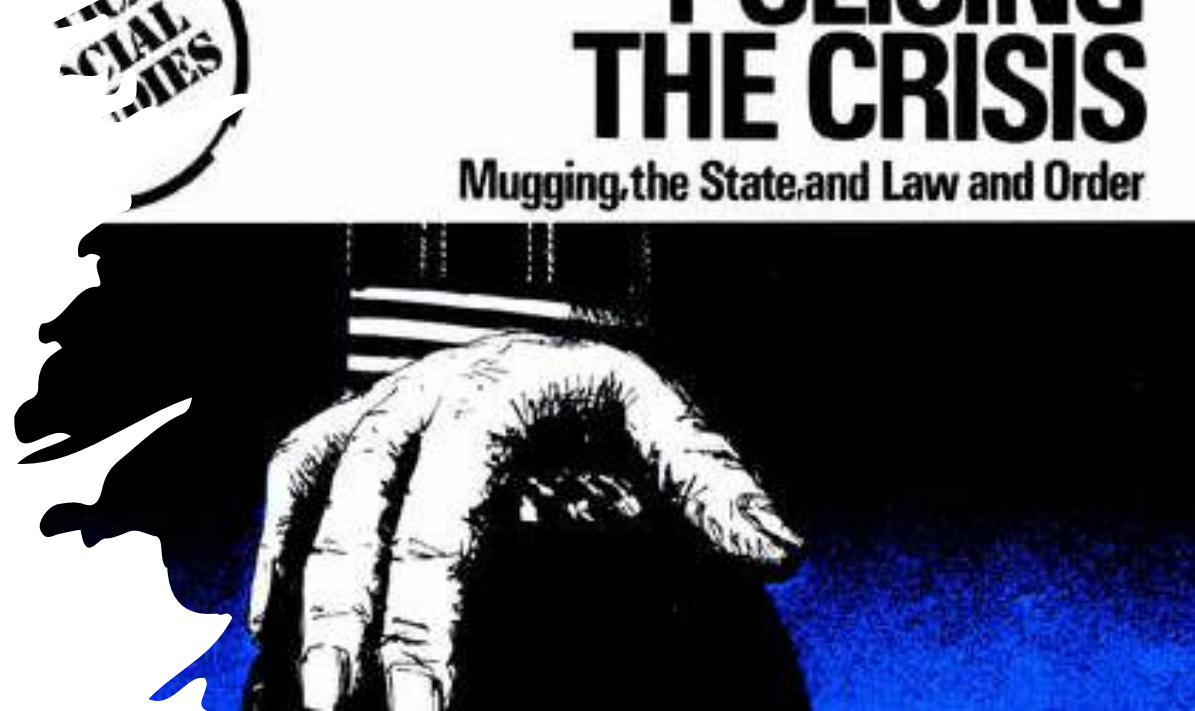
Hall (1981) 'The Whites of Their Eyes: Racist Ideologies and the Media'

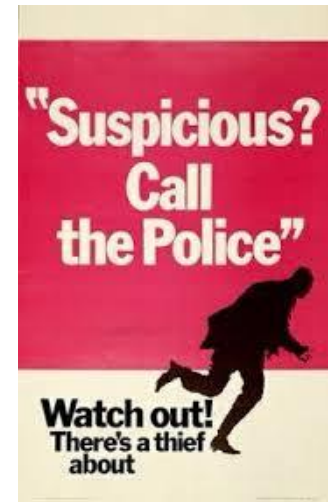


The 'grammar of race'

- Negative racial stereotypes **encoded** in film and television (slave figure, native, clown / entertainer)
- **Traces** observed even if not so apparent.
- Race as a problem
- Decoding – **contradictions** and **ambivalence** .
- **Contradiction:** Decoded by viewers in ways that might contradict the encoding.
- **Ambivalence:** Comedy protects / defends viewer from acknowledging racism.

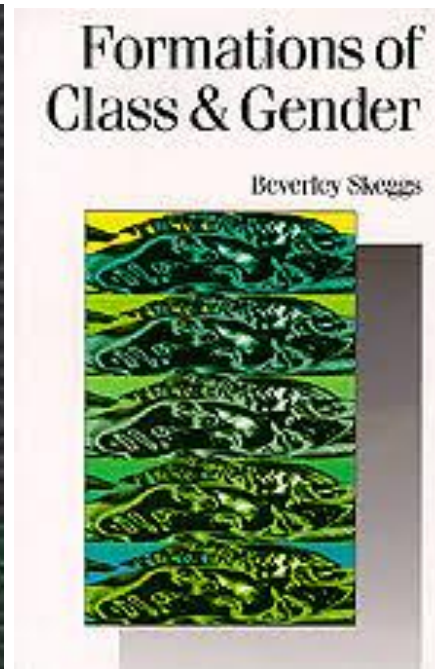
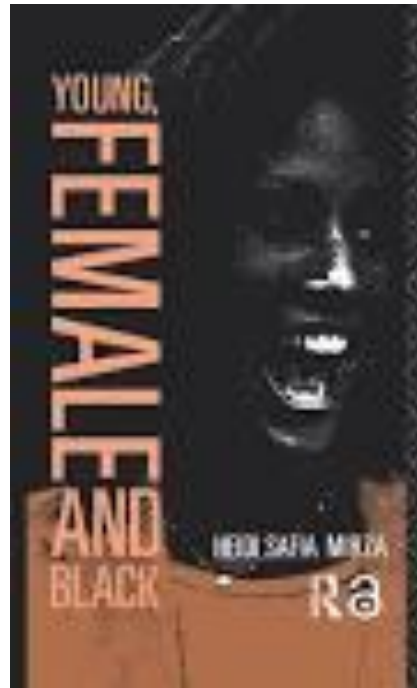
Stuart Hall:
Policing The
Crisis: Mugging,
the State, and
Law and Order
(1978)





PICKET ORGANIZED TO DEVELOP THE OPPOSITION OF THE PEOPLE TO RACIST ATTACKS

Sociological Legacy: class, gender, race, culture





**Reading: The Raymond Williams
reader (Culture is Ordinary)**

Class exercise: subcultural analysis



- A legacy of the CCCS was the analysis of sub-cultures (such as Hippies, Punks, Mods)
- Identify one contemporary youth sub-culture. What are its features (draw an example if you like)? Do participants have **relative autonomy**? Are they the subject of a **moral panic**? Are they **self-made** or **mass produced**? What does their presentation **encode** and how might it be **decoded** using Hall's framework?

